

EcoThrive

CONSULTING

Smart AI for Sustainable Impact.

Lab 3: EcoPreserve Team Report

Team 3 EcoPreserve

SE 395-2: AI Tools for Social Impact

Fall 2026

Introduction

This report brings together three research areas from the team's discovery work with EcoPreserve: operations and workflow, stakeholder relationships, and potential AI opportunities. The findings are grounded in the partner visit and reflect what the team currently knows. Where information has not yet been confirmed, the report keeps those points as open questions rather than treating them as established problems.

EcoPreserve is a sustainability consulting organization working on green building certification, electrification planning, grant support, building decarbonization, and related sustainability projects for government agencies and large organizations. Green building certification was described during the visit as a major part of the business. The organization already uses tools such as Microsoft Copilot, Grammarly, and Google NotebookLM, but professional judgment remains central to its work.

1. Operations Map

Section by Jillian Shapiro

EcoPreserve's work is project based and can vary between in-person and remote work. Different projects involve different clients, requirements, research needs, and outside partners. Green building certification, for example, may involve reviewing sustainability requirements, working with architects, collecting information, checking whether requirements are being met, and preparing documentation. The exact sequence of these steps still needs to be confirmed with EcoPreserve.

Other projects include electrification, grant funding, and decarbonization. These may require research, data collection, communication with outside partners, and final reports or recommendations. Because the organization works across several project types, an important discovery question is how consistent its internal project processes are.

Potential workflow issue to validate

The team does not yet know that EcoPreserve has an inconsistent-workflow problem. However, it is worth learning whether similar projects follow similar steps or whether the process depends mainly on the individual leading the project. Important areas include how deadlines are tracked, where documents and research are stored, how next steps are recorded, and how easily another employee could understand or take over a project.

Open questions

- Do similar projects follow the same basic process?
- How are deadlines, project status, and next steps currently tracked?
- Where are project files and research stored?
- What tasks are repeated manually and take the most time?

• Where do projects usually slow down?

• How easy would it be for one employee to take over another employee's project? • How are Grammarly and NotebookLM actually used in day-to-day work?

2. Stakeholder Map

Section by Ryan Conroy

EcoPreserve's work depends on relationships among leadership, consultants, clients, partner firms, certification reviewers, technology providers, communities, and university collaborators. Influence is distributed across these groups: different stakeholders shape business opportunities, working methods, technical recommendations, and implementation. The partner visit primarily captured Oscar's perspective, so the needs of other stakeholders still require validation.

Stakeholder group	*Relationship and supported needs*	*Still to confirm*
Oscar and employees	Oscar is CEO, owner, and student contact. Senior consultants use AI while retaining professional judgment and responsibility; marketing and administrative staff also support the firm.	❖ Workflow ownership ❖ Staff needs ❖ Who approves changes
Client organizations	Approximately 50-60 organizations annually across multiple states, mostly governments and regional authorities. Priorities include sustainability expertise, savings, resilience, and financial risk. At least one client prohibits AI and requires written confirmation.	❖ Individual priorities ❖ Decision-makers ❖ Payment arrangements ❖ Project-specific restrictions
Partner firms and project collaborators	Partner companies help EcoPreserve access large contracts, often with EcoPreserve serving as a specialist subconsultant. Architects and construction teams collaborate on green building projects.	❖ Information handoffs ❖ Proposal responsibilities ❖ Approvals ❖ Delivery expectations

Certification bodies and funding sources	LEED requirements and reviewers shape documentation and revisions. B Corp influences internal practices, while funding availability affects client implementation.	❖ Specific obligations ❖ Evidence providers ❖ Funding dependencies
Technology providers	Copilot, Grammarly, NotebookLM, and BidPrime support work, although staff still filter irrelevant solicitation results.	❖ Tool ownership ❖ Service arrangements ❖ Actual workflow benefits
Communities and outreach audiences	Communities experience the effects of implementation. Some projects include engagement; nonprofits receive donations and a large newsletter audience receives educational content.	❖ Participants' needs ❖ Engagement influence ❖ Demonstrated outcomes

What the findings mean

Clients, partners, and beneficiaries are not interchangeable. Client organizations receive services, while a partner firm may contract with EcoPreserve through a subcontracting relationship. Communities can experience project outcomes without purchasing services or controlling decisions. Payment flows and several decision roles remain unconfirmed.

Documented tensions include AI use versus client prohibitions, sustainability ambitions versus limited resources, and coordination needs versus stretched government teams. Other possible conflicts, such as disagreements over fees, deadlines, or community priorities, should remain hypotheses until the team has evidence.

Open questions

- Who performs, reviews, and approves each priority workflow?
- How are client AI restrictions communicated and enforced?
- Where do owners, partners, and consultants' handoffs cause delays?
- What different outcomes define success for staff, clients, and partners?
- Whose input shapes recommendations, especially within affected communities?

3. Opportunity Analysis

Section by Xavier Davis

EcoPreserve already uses AI, but several areas of its work remain manual. Microsoft Copilot, Grammarly, and Google NotebookLM are used for activities such as research, brainstorming, organizing information, and improving writing. The strongest opportunity is not to replace consultants, but to use AI to reduce repetitive work while keeping professional judgment with the people responsible for client recommendations.

Partner evidence: executive summary problem

Oscar described a project for a large local government that included roughly a 25-page report and an Excel file with multiple worksheets. He wanted to turn the material into a simple one-page document an executive could quickly understand. He tried Copilot and NotebookLM, but although the tools produced a document, the output was difficult to edit and use. After several attempts, he recreated it himself. This example shows both the potential and the limitation of AI: producing an output does not automatically mean the tool saves time.

Opportunity 1: Executive summaries and reports

This is the strongest starting opportunity because it is tied to a problem Oscar actually described. Consultants would still decide which findings and recommendations matter, while AI could help turn approved information into a shorter, clearer, editable document for decision-makers.

Opportunity 2: Certification documentation support

Certifications such as LEED involve requirements, calculations, document collection, submissions, and possible review comments. Because some steps repeat across projects, AI may be useful for organizing documents, tracking requirements, or preparing first drafts. This should support, not replace, consultant expertise.

Opportunity 3: Proposal preparation

Proposal preparation was also described as relatively manual. AI could potentially help structure or draft parts of proposals, but any solution would need to respect client restrictions and preserve consultant review.

Open questions

- Which of these tasks takes the team the most time each month?
- What specifically went wrong with the attempted one-page executive summary?
- Which part of the certification process consumes the most time?
- Which AI tools are permitted for each client, and what privacy requirements apply?

Conclusion: Priorities for the Next Phase

Across the three sections, the team's findings point toward improving how information moves through EcoPreserve's existing work rather than replacing expert consulting. The operations analysis raises questions about repeated manual work and project consistency. The stakeholder map shows that any workflow change must account for consultant judgment, client restrictions, partner handoffs, and certification requirements. The opportunity analysis then identifies three practical areas to investigate further.

1. Executive summary and report support. This should be investigated first because Oscar provided a specific example where current AI tools did not produce an editable, time-saving result.
2. Certification-document support. Repetitive requirements and document handling may create an opportunity for AI-assisted organization and drafting, but the exact bottleneck still needs to be confirmed.
3. Proposal preparation. Proposal work may benefit from drafting assistance, but its value depends on how much time it currently consumes and what client restrictions apply. These are discovery priorities rather than final recommendations. The next partner conversation should test the open questions in each section, identify which workflow actually consumes the most staff time, and confirm where AI assistance would be both useful and acceptable.